

Chapter 75-3

Xu Qingzhu was slumped over the steering wheel, her back arched in a curve.

The wind blew and sobered Liang Shi up considerably. She stood in the wind, the hem of her fitted trench coat dancing wildly.

She hesitated for a moment and was about to step forward when Xu Qingzhu suddenly lifted her head.

Their eyes met across the distance. Liang Shi opened her mouth but couldn't say anything, only watching as Xu Qingzhu smiled.

Xu Qingzhu tucked her hair behind her ear, leaned back in her seat, and also smiled carelessly.

Only then did Liang Shi step forward. She opened the car door and keenly caught a scent that didn't belong to Xu Qingzhu.

It was the scent of an adult Alpha.

Liang Shi frowned but quickly smoothed her expression. She didn't ask anything, only saying to Xu Qingzhu: "Teacher Xu, welcome home."

Xu Qingzhu tilted her head up and sniffed lightly. "Teacher Liang, how much did you drink?"

"Just a little," Liang Shi said. "Not much. Zhao Xuning got drunk."

"Oh~" Xu Qingzhu drew out the syllable, as if teasing.

She didn't mock her for still having Zhao Xuning call the designated driver for her.

"Alright." Liang Shi chose to skip this topic and asked her, "Have you eaten?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "I had a piece of bread in the evening."

"Then come inside," Liang Shi said. "I'll cook some noodles for you."

"Can you add a poached egg?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi nodded with certainty. "Yes."

Neither of them brought up that sensitive topic.

After returning to the villa, Liang Shi took off her trench coat and busied herself in the kitchen. She first poured herself a glass of honey water to help sober up, then turned on the gas stove to cook noodles.

The kitchen door wasn't closed. Xu Qingzhu half-reclined on the sofa, gazing at Liang Shi's back from afar.

The lights in the house were brighter than usual—stepping inside immediately felt heartwarming.

Bright tones would lift one's mood along with them. She nestled in the sofa and kept thinking about Su Zhe's words.

She finally understood why Su Zhe had said this wasn't a black-and-white choice.

Even with mental preparation, she still needed time to adapt to the truth.

She decided to go back home tomorrow if she had time. She couldn't just listen to one side of the story about the past.

Just as she was planning for tomorrow, Liang Shi called out to her: "Teacher Xu, the noodles are ready. Come eat."

Only then did Xu Qingzhu get up and walk toward the dining table. As she passed by Liang Shi, her back accidentally brushed against the back of Liang Shi's hand. Liang Shi frowned and said, "Why is your back so cold?"

Xu Qingzhu sat down in a chair and answered in a low voice, "I don't know."

"Go upstairs and change into something warmer later," Liang Shi said. "The temperature is going to drop again soon, and it'll rain tomorrow. Don't think you can ignore the weather just because you're young. Change into fleece-lined pants tomorrow, or you'll get chronic joint pain in your legs."¹

Liang Shi rambled on with her reminders, pouring out everything she could think of all at once.

Xu Qingzhu took a bite of noodles and suddenly interrupted her, "Teacher Liang, the noodles are too salty."

Liang Shi was surprised. "No, they're not?"

Xu Qingzhu picked up a chopstick full of noodles. "Try it if you don't believe me."

She said it with such certainty that Liang Shi suspiciously bent down and took a bite.

"The taste is just right," Liang Shi said. "Do you have a light palate?"

But when they had eaten together before, their tastes had been about the same.

Except that Xu Qingzhu could handle spicier food than her.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head and said, "I'm not sure, but I can't finish this much."

After hearing this, Liang Shi went to the kitchen and brought out an empty bowl. She had Xu Qingzhu transfer a few chopsticks worth of noodles into it, then held the bowl and sat across from her, looking at her with a smile. "Teacher Xu, is it not as salty now?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded, took another taste, and said, "It does seem less salty now."

Liang Shi: "Then eat more."

Xu Qingzhu didn't want to eat alone but also wanted quiet, so she expressed it in this strange way.

Liang Shi suddenly understood her.

Late into the night, the two of them shared a bowl of noodles. By the end, Xu Qingzhu discovered two eggs at the bottom of the bowl.

One fried egg and one poached egg.

"Why are there two?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi said, "I was too idle in the kitchen, so I made two."

Xu Qingzhu said, "I can't finish them."

Liang Shi passed the bowl over again.

Xu Qingzhu hesitated for a moment, then used her chopsticks to split both eggs in half, putting one half of each into Liang Shi's bowl.

Liang Shi: "....."

They finished the meal in relative quiet. While cleaning up, Liang Shi talked to Xu Qingzhu about the house situation, then naturally segued into gossiping about Zhao Xuning to help Xu Qingzhu shift her attention.

She didn't say anything too secretive, just mentioned that Zhao Xuning had dated her ex-girlfriend for six years and things were still unclear between them now.

Xu Qingzhu sighed with emotion. "Dr. Zhao's ex-girlfriend is indeed very charming."

"What's lost is always the best," Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her. "What about now?"

"Now Teacher Xu is the best," Liang Shi blurted out.

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Xu Qingzhu had been sitting on the sofa, hugging a pillow and spacing out, looking somewhat listless. But hearing Liang Shi's words now, she couldn't help but laugh. "Teacher Liang, exactly how much did you drink? You're still not sober?"

Liang Shi walked out of the kitchen, backlit, her hands that had just been in water gleaming white. She leaned against the doorframe with a satisfied smile. "You finally laughed."

Xu Qingzhu's smile froze for an instant, then she patted the spot beside her. "Come sit."

Liang Shi walked over and sat down, prepared to listen quietly to what she had to say.

But Xu Qingzhu said, "Let's watch a horror movie!"

Liang Shi: "....."

Was this reasonable?

Deep down, Liang Shi felt it wasn't reasonable, but seeing Xu Qingzhu's eager expression, she steeled herself and agreed.

Footnotes:

¹ **Old cold legs (老寒腿)**: A Chinese colloquial term for chronic joint pain or arthritis in the legs, typically associated with cold and damp weather. It's believed to be caused by prolonged exposure to cold, especially when young, and becomes a recurring problem in old age. Hence the warning not to dress too lightly in cold weather.